

had to do with political timing—the Government seemed keen to table the Budget first—and also because Indian negotiators wanted as many reassurances about fuel supply to address Left concerns.

That required creative draftsmanship and took months of haggling. At the end of the fifth round, R.B. Grover, DAE's director of strategic planning and India's negotiator, said that "considerable progress had been made". The two sides are to hold another round to finalise the text of the deal. M.R. Srinivasan, a former Atomic Energy

clearance would enable India to conduct trade with any of the 45 member countries and not just the US—a point Mukherjee made in Parliament. The Government could then tell the Left that it could decide whether to support the US deal at that stage. But as Yechury points out: "Why would the US put its weight behind such a proposition when it may not benefit from it?"

He has a point. NSG clearance would be difficult to obtain without strong US backing. So the Indian Government has a tricky balancing act to perform. Also important is the timing. For the

reservations on the deal and wanted to have a look at the IAEA agreement, they can do so now. The finalised draft can be shared with the NSG members who meet in April which can then grant an exemption to India. The finalised draft can be adopted in the next board meeting of the IAEA board of governors or a special meeting called by the IAEA chief.

Meanwhile, the UPA accelerated its efforts to rally support for the deal. Prime Minister's special envoy Shyam Saran met former National Security Advisor Brajesh Mishra and briefed him on the details. That led to Mishra

coming out in support of the deal. Much to BJP's discomfiture, Manmohan not only mentioned Mishra's support in Parliament but also pointed out that Strobe Talbott, a key US negotiator when the BJP-led NDA was in power, had said that the A.B. Vajpayee government would have even agreed for "50 per cent of what was being offered now" if the then US administration had proposed it. Manmohan has also appealed to Vajpayee to lend support to the deal.

Left leaders like Yechury are banking on the fact that the Congress may not want to risk its post budget election agenda by



President Bush (right) at the US Congress

US CONGRESS: With the NSG clearance, the Bush administration will seek the US Congress vote on the 123 Agreement. It has to do so by July or the deal may have to wait for the next US Presidency.

Commission (AEC) chairman, said that when he met IAEA Director-General Mohamed ElBaradei, he got the impression that "things were moving in the right direction and there were no insurmountable hurdles."

The crunch would come when the finalised text of the agreement is placed before the UPA-Left committee. The Government's effort would first be to bring the Left to see reason, especially if the IAEA agreement meets all their concerns. It could argue that since the Left parties had wanted India to sign a deal to buy Russian reactors, negotiations couldn't proceed till they had such an IAEA safeguards agreement signed and also an NSG clearance. The NSG

US Congress to clear the agreement, it requires that it be placed no later than June or July, which would give it 90 days to deliberate on the deal and put it to vote. It means that the IAEA agreement must be ready by mid-April giving at least two months for NSG countries to exempt India.

Instead of a confrontation, the Left could delay matters by requesting for time to examine the IAEA agreement. That could be got around though with some difficulty. Officials say that it is not a binding clause that prior to an NSG waiver the additional safeguards protocol is ratified by the IAEA. But since some of the NSG members had some

breaking up the coalition over the nuclear deal. It would take the voters' attention away from domestic issues and give BJP the ammunition that the Congress couldn't run a coalition government. Also, it may suit the Congress to first win crucial state polls, in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan, where they are banking on anti-incumbency, and then go for a general election. In short, the Indo-US nuclear deal could go into limbo.

There are, however, those in the Congress who argue that it is time to call the Left's bluff and go ahead with the deal. Also given that Manmohan's personal prestige rests on it, as does India's in the international scenario, the Congress isn't going to give in easily. The next few weeks would show as nuclear analyst G. Balachandran says: "Who is really chicken?" ■